

FREE SAMPLE

Bearded Dragon Care Package

The first 5 pages of the 50-page printable manual, free to keep.



In this sample: What's inside, How to Use This Package, Quick Profile & Cost Overview, The Species, Morphs, Size & Lifespan. The contents page shows every one of the 50 pages, so you can see exactly what the full package covers before you buy it.

Not in this sample: the 45 pages that follow, which are the full care guide, the health section, the quick reference cards, and the owner tools, checklists and logs.

The full package is \$8.99 at beastlyfacts.com/care-packages/bearded-dragon/. One purchase, and every corrected edition is a free re-download from your library. The free bearded dragon care guide it was built from is at beastlyfacts.com/guides/bearded-dragon/, and stays free.

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Every page is written to be used, not just read once.

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START HERE

How to use this package

Three ways to get value from it, depending on where you are right now.

UNITS USED THROUGHOUT

Every temperature and size is given twice. Temperatures appear in degrees Fahrenheit (°F) with degrees Celsius (°C) beside them. Sizes appear in inches (in) and feet (ft), with centimeters (cm) beside them. A dragon and its weight log are measured in grams (g), the unit a kitchen scale shows. Humidity is a percentage (%) of the moisture the air could hold. Prices are in United States dollars.

If you haven't set up yet

Check the law first, on page 26: a bearded dragon is legal without a permit in most of the United States, but not everywhere. Then read pages 4 to 12 in order before buying anything. Housing, temperature and UVB decisions are expensive to redo, so get the enclosure size and the lighting right the first time, and use the Budget & Shopping List on page 36 to buy once.

If your dragon is already home

Audit what you have against the Setup Checklist in the print list below, and go to the Red Flags page (page 27) if anything seems off. The food charts starting on page 14 are worth a read even for experienced keepers, since most diet problems come from a food that was fine "once in a while" becoming a daily habit.

Print these first

- | | |
|--|--|
| ☐ Page 34: Setup Checklist & Targets | ☐ Page 42: Pet-Sitter Sheet |
| ☐ Page 35: Emergency & Quick Targets Card | ☐ Page 43: Owner Log |
| ☐ Page 39: Symptom Quick Reference | ☐ Page 44: Equipment & Vet Log |
| ☐ Page 40: Daily, Weekly & Seasonal Routine | ☐ Page 45: Enrichment Checklist & Log |

WHY THIS PACKAGE EXISTS

Bearded dragon care has changed a lot in the last decade. This package reflects current UVB, enclosure-size and diet standards, cross-checked against the veterinary and scientific sources listed on page 48.

NOT A SUBSTITUTE FOR

A reptile-experienced veterinarian. This is a husbandry reference for day-to-day care. Anything urgent or health-related is always a vet call, not a page in this book. Find a reptile vet before you need one and write the number on the emergency card. Nothing on the law page is legal advice either.

Quick profile

Everything at a glance before you read the detail.

Scientific name	<i>Pogona vitticeps</i> (inland or central bearded dragon)
Adult size	16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm) nose to tail; 300 to 500 g, big males heavier
Captive lifespan	10 to 15 years with consistent care
Native range	Arid woodland, scrubland and rocky desert in the central and eastern interior of Australia
Diet type	Omnivore: mostly insects when young, mostly greens as an adult (page 13)
Enclosure minimum (adult)	4×2×2 ft (120×60×60 cm, about 120 gallons), front-opening preferred
UVB requirement	A linear T5 HO (high-output, 5/8 inch) tube, giving a UVI (ultraviolet index, the strength of the UVB) of 4.0 to 4.5 at the basking spot
Sexual maturity	Around 12 to 18 months; females can lay infertile eggs without a male (page 23)
Handling difficulty	Beginner to intermediate; generally tolerant once settled
Conservation status	Least Concern, the lowest-risk grade on the global list of threatened species

Cost overview

Initial setup

\$40 to \$100 for a standard dragon, \$575 to \$1,280 for the equipment, plus \$120 to \$245 for the first vet exam and fecal test (a stool check for parasites). Every line is on page 36.

Monthly ongoing

\$75 to \$145 for feeders, greens, supplements, electricity, bulbs and the yearly vet visit, averaged.

BUDGET FOR THE WORST CASE TOO

Emergency care isn't rare enough to ignore: impaction surgery commonly runs \$800 to \$2,500, and MBD (metabolic bone disease) treatment \$200 to \$500 or more. Neither is likely if you follow this package, but plan for both.

Fun facts worth knowing

- The "beard" is a flap of spiny skin under the chin that darkens and puffs out during stress, territorial display, or breeding, not a sign of aggression by itself.
- They darken their backs to absorb heat when cool and lighten when warm, an effect measured in wild dragons.
- They can see ultraviolet light through a fourth type of cone cell, which is part of why lighting affects appetite and mood, not just bones.

The species, morphs, size & lifespan

What you are buying, how big it gets, and how long it stays.

One species

The pet bearded dragon is *Pogona vitticeps*, the inland or central bearded dragon. It is the species the pet trade sells, and the only one this package covers. In the wild it lives in the arid and semi-arid interior of central and eastern Australia, basking on rocks and fence posts in open woodland and scrubland and eating insects, plants, flowers and the occasional small vertebrate. It is active by day and solitary: two dragons do not keep each other company, and every one does best housed alone. It takes its name from the expandable, spiny throat pouch, the "beard," which darkens toward black when the dragon is threatened or excited.

Morphs

A morph is a captive-bred line that looks different from the natural, wild-type dragon: a different color, pattern, or skin. A standard dragon costs \$40 to \$100. The care in this package applies to every morph with one exception. Hypomelanistic (reduced dark pigment), silkback and translucent morphs are more sensitive to UVB and can be burned by standard output, so their basking spot gets a UVI of 3.0 or lower instead of 4.0 to 4.5 (page 9).

Size and growth

Adult length	16 to 24 in (41 to 61 cm) nose to tail tip. Most healthy adults measure 18 to 22 in (45 to 56 cm).
Adult weight	300 to 500 g is typical, and large males run heavier. Frame size varies between dragons the way it does between people, so two healthy adults can sit at different ends of that range.
Growth	From under 10 g at hatching to over 300 g in about a year and a half. Most of the length comes in the first year, and growth slows sharply once the dragon reaches sexual maturity at around 12 to 18 months.
Males and females	Adult males are slightly larger, with bigger heads and darker beard displays. Telling them apart reliably takes until about 4 to 6 months of age.

Lifespan

10 to 15 years is typical in captivity with good care. Wild dragons live 5 to 8 years, because predation and disease cut them short. A dragon bought for a child can still be in the house when that child leaves home, so plan for the whole span: the routine and a reptile vet for every one of those years.

CAPTIVE-BRED IS THE ONLY KIND THERE IS

Australia banned the commercial export of its live native animals in 1982, and no legal supply has left the country since. Every bearded dragon outside Australia descends from stock that got out before or around that ban, and large-scale breeding only took hold in Europe and the United States in the 1990s. So the American trade is entirely captive-bred, with no lawful wild-caught supply. A young, captive-raised dragon makes the better pet; an older, imported animal is harder to tame and more likely to carry intestinal parasites. What to look for in the animal itself is on page 22.